

The Mercedes-Benz GLS 450 Night Edition is proof that even the automotive equivalent of a private member's club occasionally fancies staying out late. The standard GLS has always been formal, all chrome, ceremony and upright good manners; this limited-run version loosens the dress code. Alpine Grey or Obsidian Black paint is paired with a darkened exterior treatment, turning that enormous grille from jewellery into intimidation. On something this large, black trim can look like a tuning-shop afterthought, but here it has the opposite effect, visually tightening the car and lending its generous proportions a more tailored severity. It is still unmistakably a GLS, a three-row flagship that occupies road space with the confidence of diplomatic property, only now it appears to have plans after dinner.

There is nothing nocturnal about the way the GLS 450 moves. Its 3-litre turbocharged straight-six produces 386PS and 500Nm, sent through a nine-speed automatic, with mild-hybrid assistance filling the pause before the engine gathers itself. Mercedes-Benz claims 0–100kmph in 6.1 seconds, an indecently brisk figure for something resembling a well-appointed townhouse. The appeal, however, is not in repeatedly launching it from traffic lights. The engine is at its best delivering one long, silken swell of acceleration, accompanied by a cultured growl that never raises its voice enough to disturb the upholstery. The air suspension largely insulates the cabin from India's more creative road surfaces, although sharp edges can remind you that vast wheels remain vast wheels. Ask it to attack a bend and the body takes a moment to collect itself; settle into its rhythm, though, and grip and composure are impressive. This is less sports car impersonation than first-class travel conducted at suspicious speed.





★★

SPECIFICATIONS

Engine 2,999 cc, turbocharged inline-six petrol (mild-hybrid)
Power 280 kW, plus 15 kW electric boost
Torque 500 Nm
Transmission 9-speed automatic
0–100 kmph 6.1 seconds
Top speed 250 kmph
Price 1.4 crore, ex-showroom

★★

Inside, the Night Edition earns its name more convincingly. Black Nappa leather and Anthracite open-pore oak replace the usual drawing-room brightness with something moodier, while the standard head-up display adds useful theatre without demanding attention. The cabin remains the real argument for the GLS: broad, beautifully finished and sufficiently spacious for adults across the first two rows, with a third row best reserved for shorter journeys. Screens proliferate, including rear entertainment displays, yet the atmosphere is more lounge than electronics showroom; five-zone climate control, ventilated seats and the Burmester system work discreetly. It is not flawless. The steering is light on conversation, and its sheer size can turn a basement car park into an aptitude test. But few cars make family logistics feel this ceremonial. The Night Edition does not reinvent the GLS; it dims the lights, swaps the silverware for black tie and makes excess look rather well bred.